

# Welcome to America: A Research-Grounded Platform for U.S. Immigration Navigation

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v1: <https://github.com/juanms23/welcome-to-america>

v2: <https://github.com/JoeyPatricio/Welcome-to-America-2.0>

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## Abstract

The United States immigration system is among the most administratively complex in the world, yet the tools available to people navigating it range from costly to inaccessible to absent. This paper describes the research foundations, problem context, and design rationale behind Welcome to America 2.0, a free web-based platform built to give immigrants direct access to civic guides, legal information, and local support organizations. The design draws on empirical research in digital inclusion, public information theory, and participatory user research conducted with community members with firsthand immigration experience.

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## 1. The Problem

The United States is home to roughly one-fifth of the world's international migrants. In 2022, approximately 11 million unauthorized immigrants lived in the country alongside a much larger population of legal residents, visa holders, and naturalized citizens working through various stages of the immigration process. Immigrants make up about 20% of the U.S. workforce, concentrated in education, health services, construction, manufacturing, and agriculture.

Despite this scale, the information infrastructure supporting immigrants is fractured. A

person trying to understand their visa status, renew a green card, enroll a child in school, or find a legal aid attorney faces a search across dozens of government websites, nonprofit directories, and legal databases, most of which assume either English fluency, legal literacy, or both. The alternative is paying for help. Platforms like SimpleCitizen offer guided form preparation with optional attorney review, but charge between \$229 and \$1,139 per application. The Immigrant Legal Resource Center (ILRC) maintains deep legal resources but targets attorneys and advocates rather than immigrants directly.

The gap is not simply one of access. Research by Kustov and Landgrave (2025), published in the *Journal of Experimental Political Science*, found that most Americans, across political and demographic groups, lack basic knowledge of how the legal immigration process works. The study ran a nationally representative survey experiment ( $N=1,000$ ) in which participants received short verifiable narratives about the difficulty of the legal immigration admissions process. The intervention produced a measurable shift toward support for more open immigration policies. The finding is significant for platform design: people change their understanding when given accurate, concrete information about the process. The same logic applies to immigrants themselves, who frequently report that the biggest barrier to starting an application is not knowing where to begin.

Ma et al. (2016), studying urban migrant workers and elderly people in China at the IEEE International Conference on Computer Communication and the Internet, identified three categories of barriers preventing information-disadvantaged populations from adopting mobile internet services: system factors (confusing interfaces, unclear feedback), social factors (isolation from peer networks who use technology), and individual factors (limited prior experience, fear of making errors). The study found that two instructional strategies produced measurable improvement in adoption: visual step-by-step guidance and security framing, meaning telling users explicitly that their information was protected. These findings translate across contexts. An immigrant in the United States using an unfamiliar government

website faces the same convergence of factors: an interface that assumes expertise, no peer community to ask, and no reassurance that using the site is safe.

Together, these studies establish the core problem Welcome to America addresses: the immigration information deficit is real, documented, and solvable through accessible, trustworthy, well-structured tools.

## 2. Why Existing Systems Fall Short

Two categories of systems currently serve this space. Commercial platforms automate form preparation but charge for the service. Nonprofit resource hubs publish legal guidance but aim it at professionals rather than applicants.

SimpleCitizen exemplifies the commercial model. Its three-step process—answer questions, review with attorneys, print and mail—is well-designed and demonstrably effective, having assisted users from over 80 countries with a 4.9-star average from more than 1,000 reviews. Its acquisition by Fragomen, one of the largest immigration law firms in the world, validates its legal rigor. The problem is price. A family navigating a green card application and renewal, plus citizenship, could pay over \$2,000. The populations with the most urgent need—undocumented immigrants, recent arrivals, and low-income workers—are exactly the populations that price point excludes.

The ILRC model presents a different gap. Its website organizes immigration law by topic area (asylum, DACA, detention, removal defense, and others), publishes practice advisories and toolkits, and hosts webinars for legal practitioners. The quality is high. The audience is wrong. An immigrant trying to understand their rights after an ICE encounter cannot use a practice advisory written for a criminal defense attorney. The ILRC's weakness is that it requires a lawyer to translate it. Two design lessons follow from this: legal information must be written for direct users, and local resource connections matter more than comprehensive coverage of legal theory.

Both gaps were confirmed through participatory user research detailed in the following section.

### **3. Participatory User Research**

To ground the platform’s design in lived experience rather than assumption, a structured interview was conducted with a community member who holds firsthand knowledge of both immigration and the systems serving immigrant populations.

#### **3.1 Participant Profile**

The participant is a 61-year-old program coordinator with Clark County government in Washington State. In that role, he oversees community contracts providing substance use and mental health services, giving him institutional familiarity with how public resources reach underserved populations. He immigrated to the United States from the Philippines at age eight. His father petitioned for the family in 1972; they were naturalized in 1975. He holds a bachelor’s degree. At the time of the interview, he was actively pursuing dual citizenship with the Philippines, navigating that process primarily through internet research.

His immigration experience was largely handled by his parents when he was a child, so he does not speak from a position of personal struggle with the process. He speaks instead from a position of sustained proximity: he hears frequently from Filipino and East Asian community members about how lengthy and opaque U.S. immigration is, and he works professionally with populations that face systemic barriers to accessing services.

#### **3.2 Interview Protocol**

The interview followed a structured questionnaire across four phases: background questions, participatory review of the prototype, suggestions for improvement, and closing questions about emotional and community support. The participant reviewed a working prototype of the Welcome to America interface during the session.

### 3.3 Key Findings

**Centralization as primary value.** When asked how the platform differed from other immigration resources he was aware of, the participant identified consolidation as the defining advantage. He described the current experience of researching immigration questions as moving in and out of separate sites, opening new tabs, losing context, and being unable to connect information across sources. He said, in his words, “everything is in one screen.” This was not a compliment about aesthetics. It was a functional observation: a single platform that covers legal information, forms, local resources, and community support removes the coordination cost that falls entirely on the user when resources are fragmented.

**Language access as a prerequisite.** When asked on a scale of one to five how useful the platform would be for someone trying to immigrate, the participant’s first response was a question: would the content be translated into users’ native languages? He did not answer the usefulness question until he had an answer to the language question. Once told that translation across major languages was planned, he rated the platform 4 to 4.5 out of 5. The sequencing matters. He treated translation not as a feature but as a threshold condition. A platform without it is not 4.5 out of 5 minus one point; it is a different, lesser tool.

**Processing timelines as anxiety reduction.** The participant’s most concrete product suggestion was a way to understand how long each immigration process takes, from submission through government response. He framed it as expectation-setting: knowing the timeline does not speed the process, but it removes the particular anxiety of not knowing whether silence means progress, delay, or rejection. He noted that the prototype showed forms but not time. Adding timelines, in his view, would make the tool materially less stressful to use.

**Eligibility screening at entry.** The participant asked whether the platform would show users what categories they might fall under before sending them into specific guides. He described this as an “initial criteria” question: someone arriving from another country may not know whether they qualify for a green card, a work visa, or another pathway. Without a

starting screen that helps users locate themselves in the system, they face the same problem the platform is meant to solve, just one level earlier. He accepted the explanation that an intake quiz would route users to relevant content, calling it sensible once described.

**Community forums for peer experience.** When asked what emotional or community support features would help, the participant described a forum where users share experiences organized by country of origin or immigration pathway. He contrasted this with generic testimonials, suggesting the value lies in specificity: hearing from someone who went through the same process from the same starting country carries more weight than a general success story. He connected this to the experience of isolation that many immigrants feel, noting that the platform could reduce that isolation by making other people’s journeys visible and searchable.

**Digital access is not universal.** The participant flagged a structural limitation the platform cannot resolve on its own. He observed that someone trying to immigrate from a rural area of another country may not have reliable access to a phone, laptop, or internet connection. For those users, the platform is irrelevant until they reach a city or a connected resource. He did not frame this as a criticism of the platform but as a constraint on its reach. It points toward a future where partner organizations, libraries, and community centers serve as access points for users who cannot reach the platform directly.

### 3.4 Design Decisions Driven by the Interview

Four features in v2.0 trace directly to this interview. The Google Translate widget in the navigation bar is positioned based on the participant’s prioritization of language access. The processing timeline information in each civic guide responds to his suggestion about expectation-setting. The intake quiz, which routes users to relevant guides based on their situation and status, addresses his question about eligibility screening. The community forum remains on the roadmap, not yet built, because the moderation challenge it raises requires more design work than the current version supports.

## 4. Design Principles

Three principles guide the platform, each grounded in research findings.

**Plain-language information provision.** Kustov and Landgrave’s finding that verifiable, narrative-driven information shifts understanding better than demographic or economic arguments supports a specific design choice: the civic guides avoid legal jargon and lead with what users need to do, not what the law says abstractly. The green card guide explains the five-step adjustment of status process in the sequence a user would encounter it, with plain descriptions of what each form is for and what a typical timeline looks like. The legal support guide opens with a notario fraud warning because that is the first trap many immigrants encounter, not a comprehensive taxonomy of immigration law.

**Trust through transparency.** Ma et al. found that security framing—explicit communication about data protection—meaningfully increased adoption among information-disadvantaged users. The ILRC’s practice of placing a prominent privacy policy banner on its homepage reflects the same principle for a different reason: immigrants in legally ambiguous situations will not use a platform they do not trust. Welcome to America displays a privacy guarantee on every page and collects no user data. The platform requires no account and no login. A user can arrive, find what they need, and leave without leaving a record.

**Local resource connection.** The ILRC’s jurisdictional depth—organizing resources and legal guidance by state and locality—pointed to a gap in the original prototype. Immigration law varies by state. A driver’s license for an undocumented immigrant is available in 19 states and not others. Public charge rules apply differently depending on the type of benefit and the applicant’s status. A platform that gives general information without local context produces anxiety rather than reducing it. The Find Help directory addresses this by letting users filter 50+ real organizations (RAICES, the National Immigrant Justice Center, the International Rescue Committee, Legal Aid Society, and Catholic Charities affiliates, among

others) by category and ZIP code, with a statewide toggle when local options are thin.

## 5. The Platform

Welcome to America 2.0 is a free, browser-based resource hub. No download or account is required. A Google Translate widget is accessible on every page. The platform runs on a React 19 frontend and an Express 5 backend that serves the organization directory from a REST API.

### 5.1 Find Help Directory

The directory is the flagship feature of v2.0. Users enter a ZIP code and filter by category: Legal Aid, Healthcare, Mental Health, Employment, Education, Food, or Housing. The backend returns matching organizations and always appends national-scope organizations when a location filter is active. Each record includes the organization's name, description, phone number, website, supported languages, and a flag indicating whether it serves users of all immigration statuses.

The data covers 50+ real organizations. Entries include immigration legal service providers that do not charge fees, community health centers with sliding-scale care, and mental health providers with staff who speak Spanish, Tagalog, Somali, and other languages common among immigrant communities.

### 5.2 Civic Guides

Every topic page is a step-by-step guide with legal citations, written for a user with no prior legal background. The guide structure reflects the user research finding: people want to know what to do and how long it will take, in that order.

Topics covered include:

- **Registration** — USCIS account creation, Selective Service enrollment, and address

change via AR-11, with the legal consequence of failing to update one's address stated plainly.

- **Green Cards** — adjustment of status in five steps, with typical USCIS processing timelines for each stage.
- **Legal Support** — notario fraud warning, types of legal representation, and constitutional rights that apply regardless of status.
- **Employment** — work authorization by immigration status, the I-9 verification process from the employee's perspective, and worker rights that apply regardless of documentation status under federal law.
- **Driver's Licenses** — the 19 states that permit undocumented applicants to obtain a standard (non-REAL ID) license, with state-specific notes.
- **Government Assistance** — the public charge rule in plain terms, which programs are considered in a determination, and safe harbors including emergency medical care and school meal programs.
- **Healthcare** — EMTALA emergency rights, four coverage pathways by immigration status, and public charge safe harbors for healthcare use.
- **Mental Health** — the 988 crisis line, immigration-specific stressors (detention anxiety, family separation, legal uncertainty), and multilingual providers.
- **Reproductive Health** — HIPAA confidentiality protections, Title X-funded family planning services, and state variation in coverage for undocumented patients.
- **K-12 Education** — *Plyler v. Doe* (1982), which prohibits schools from denying enrollment based on immigration status, and McKinney-Vento protections for students experiencing housing instability.

- **Undocumented** — rights during an ICE encounter, sanctuary policies and their limits, DACA eligibility and current status, and post-secondary options in states with in-state tuition for undocumented students.

### 5.3 Language Access

The Google Translate widget is persistent across all pages. This design choice comes directly from user research. The participant’s first response to a question about usefulness was a question about translation. Ma et al. identified language barriers as one of the primary factors preventing information-disadvantaged populations from adopting digital services. The widget is placed in the navigation bar, not buried in a footer, so it is visible before a user reads a word of content.

### 5.4 Processing Timelines

Following the user research finding that people want to understand how long processes take, each guide includes USCIS-reported typical processing times where available. Green card adjustment of status processing currently runs 8 to 48 months depending on the applicant’s country of birth and visa category. Citizenship applications typically take 8 to 14 months from filing to oath ceremony. Work authorization renewals must be filed at least 180 days before expiration to avoid gaps in employment eligibility. These timelines are sourced from USCIS processing time data and updated when USCIS publishes revised estimates.

## 6. What the Platform Does Not Do

Welcome to America does not file forms on behalf of users, generate completed USCIS documents, or provide legal advice. The Legal Support guide states this clearly and routes users toward free legal aid rather than substituting for it. The distinction matters. A platform that implies it can replace an attorney puts users at risk. One that explains what legal help looks like and how to find it for free serves users more safely.

The platform does not use AI-powered chat support. For users with limited digital literacy or unreliable internet connections, a conversational interface introduces more failure points than it resolves. Ma et al. found that simplified, predictable workflows reduce anxiety for information-disadvantaged users better than open-ended interaction. A static guide with a clear structure delivers more reliably than a chatbot that may misunderstand a question or produce an incorrect legal summary.

## **7. Limitations and Future Work**

The organization directory covers 50+ entries but is not comprehensive. Coverage is stronger for large cities and weaker for rural areas, which are home to significant agricultural immigrant populations. Future development should expand rural coverage and add a mechanism for organizations to submit and update their own listings.

The civic guides are written in English and machine-translated through the Google widget. Translation quality varies by language and legal terminology translates inconsistently. Full professional localization, starting with Spanish and Tagalog given their prevalence among U.S. immigrant communities, would substantially improve the platform's reach.

The community forum feature suggested in user research has not been built. A moderated forum where users share experiences by country of origin and immigration pathway would add the peer-network dimension that Ma et al. identified as a key enabler of technology adoption. It would also fulfill the insight from Kustov and Landgrave that first-person narratives shift understanding more than statistics. The design challenge is moderation: immigration advice shared by non-experts can be wrong, and wrong advice in this context causes real harm.

## **8. Conclusion**

The U.S. immigration information gap has two faces. Immigrants lack clear, accessible, trustworthy guidance on a process that can determine whether they stay or are deported,

whether their children can attend school, and whether they can legally work. The broader public lacks the factual foundation to support good immigration policy. Welcome to America 2.0 addresses the first problem directly and the second indirectly, through guides that explain the process as it is, not as political debate frames it.

The platform is free, requires no account, and works on any device with a browser. Its design follows the research: plain language, explicit trust signals, local resource connections, and step-by-step process guidance with realistic time estimates. Existing platforms either charge for these services or write them for lawyers. Welcome to America 2.0 writes them for the people who need them.

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